THE PRIEST, THE BEDOUINS, AND THE KIDNAPPED AFRICANS

They came north from war-torn Eritrea hoping for a better life. But instead of reaching safety and the chance to start a better life they were intercepted by kidnappers and kept in brutal conditions. Many of them have wound up stuck in Egypt, where they remain in limbo.

BY MAX SIEGELBAUM AND GIULIA BERTOLUZZI

WHEN FATHER IBRAHIM'S PHONE RINGS, it's rarely good news. Several years ago, the Cairo-based Eritrean priest received a call from an unknown number. The young man on the other end of the line explained that he had purchased a group of kidnapped Eritreans from an armed gang, and was in the process of extorting money from their families abroad. The problem, he said, was that Eritreans speak Tigrigna, a complicated language completely indecipherable to the Egyptian-Arabic speaking kidnapper.

"Are you the priest?" he asked. "You need to help us."

And just like that, Father Ibrahim, who declined to give his full name, became an intermediary in a then nascent, brutal trade: the buying and selling of human beings. It would quickly grow into a sizable industry, implicating government officials in three countries. Hundreds of thousands of dollars have since exchanged hands between violent criminal gangs, and hundreds have been left dead or in jail in its wake.

With a disarming smile that reveals a mouth full of gold teeth, Father Ibrahim paces the tidy grounds of his church, next to a row of soot-blackened auto repair shops in Cairo's working class Abbasiya. Wearing a suede jacket, a blue button down shirt and khaki pants, Father Ibrahim, is an unconventional looking priest. More a multipurpose compound than a place of worship, his church grounds include bunkrooms, a cafeteria, and a soccer field. His parish is mainly comprised of the often blighted, but longstanding and sizable Sudanese refugee population, estimated in the tens of thousands. He serves as teacher, social worker, family counsellor, lawyer, and activist African refugees in Cairo have a particularly hard time surviving city life. Refugees face daily racism, never get legal standing to hold a job or send their children to public schools. Most are forced to survive off of around $20 to $60 a month from aid agency handouts. Father Ibrahim serves in a small community of overburdened religious figures who work underground to provide education, medical assistance, and legal guidance when refugees run afoul of the law.

When the kidnappers initially contacted him, he tried to refuse. "I tried to negotiate. I changed my name. I constantly changed my phone number," he says. "This was no easy thing." He was left with little choice to comply, but has tried to use his unique skills – he is one of the few Eritreans fluent in Arabic, Tigrigna, and English – to make a positive difference. Father Ibrahim works largely as a translator, delivering messages on behalf of the traffickers, and negotiating the release of the Eritreans trapped in the Sinai. He works in the shadows, traveling to Sinai under false pretenses, constantly changing his name and identity. He faces serious reprisal from the Egyptian government, which often hunts after Christian organisations for operating in the country, and the highly organised and persistent kidnapping networks which prowl the districts and cafes where Eritreans congregate, to further terrorise and extort their victims. Father Ibrahim receives no payment or acknowledgement for his services, and instead sees it as an opportunity to help a struggling group of young men from his home country.

Eritreans are relatively easy prey for trafficking due to the extremely poor living standards at home. Following independence from European powers in 1947, the Federation of Ethiopia and Eritrea quickly descended into a chaotic thirty-year war, with Eritrea ostensibly gaining independence in 1991. Shortly afterwards, President Isaias Afewerki, leader of the People's Front for Democracy and Justice, the resistance movement largely responsible for the defeat of Ethiopian forces,

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came to power where he remains today. In the ensuing years, Afewerki has stamped out all dissenters, jailing journalists and opponents, and expunging all other political parties from the country. He also established a compulsory military service lasting eighteen months for all Eritrean men and women, which in reality extends indefinitely, forcing conscripts to remain within the country until their service finishes. Freedom of speech and religion is essentially nonexistent, and military service goes hand in hand with forced labour. According to US diplomatic cables released by WikiLeaks in 2010, the American ambassador Ronald McMullen said of Eritrea, "Young Eritreans are fleeing their country in droves, the economy appears to be in a death spiral, Eritrea's prisons are overflowing, and the country's unhinged dictator remains cruel and defiant."

"You cannot say anything against the government," says Father Ibrahim. People going missing in Eritrea is a common occurrence, as Ibrahim explains. "You cannot know where they're being taken, they throw you in prison and you are gone. In Eritrea you will find more prisons than schools or hospitals."

In the late 1990s, those willing to take a chance began to slip across the borders with Sudan and Ethiopia. Some paid smugglers to bring them north, up through Libya and across the Mediterranean into Italy. Most travelled east, through Egypt into Israel, which was then fairly welcoming to African migrant labour. There they toiled on construction sites, cleaned apartments, passed out fliers for fast food restaurants. As the economic refugees continued to flood the country, Israelis began to crack down on the migrants. They took a shoot-on site policy at the border and in the dead of night Africans who sprinted across the perimeter were gunned down. This culminated in the construction of a wall between Israel and Egypt in 2012.

In Eritrea, news from the outside world is slow. Even as Eritreans were detained or shot in the Sinai, a steady stream of young men and women continued to leave the country in droves hoping for a better life in Israel. Around 2008, they began appearing in the offices of Cairo's refugee associations.

WE TRAVEL BY BUS to the Northern Sinai in May of 2013. The region has become unstable since the Arab Spring revolution and shortly before our arrival, an unknown group has kidnapped eight Egyptian conscript soldiers from a checkpoint on a Sinai road. Tanks, armoured personnel carriers, and helicopters are converging on reported areas of activities for the Sinai's jihadist sects.

Sinai is the biblical peninsula and incendiary piece of land that drove Israel and Egypt to war in 1973. Bedouin tribes in the area have always resisted centralisation of the state and many refuse to treat Cairo as their capital. The Egyptian state has long accused Bedouins of collaborating with the Israeli government during the occupation of the Sinai, which lasted from 1967 until 1981. Bedouins have been excluded from major economic projects, including the massive hotel complexes on the Sinai's Red Sea coast. With few legal opportunities to earn a living, many turn to illegal activities, and in particular, smuggling.

Nowhere is the black market economy stronger than in northern Sinai, particularly Rafah. A line of vehicles stretches back a kilometre before the city limits. Lengths of rope cinch down misshapen wares on the backs of trucks, goods destined to be smuggled under the wall into the heart of Gaza. Israel's economic blockade of Gaza fuels a robust and diverse trade and many houses in Rafah have trap doors leading to tunnels, where smugglers, usually young men, ferry goods back and forth under the wall. Everything from painkillers, to concrete, and even KFC

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takeouts gets sent under the border. Some passageways are big enough to let full sized trucks pass through.

From Rafah, we drive south past ragged hamlets, one-room houses with corrugated tin roofs, en route to Mahadiya, a small city forty kilometers away, and the country's centre of human trafficking. Soon the shacks are replaced by larger and professionally constructed homes, three story monstrosities of marble, opalescent glass, and gold leafing. The chewed up Fiats and horse carts are replaced with Mercedes, Toyota Hilux's, Ranger Rovers, Land Rovers, and Land Cruisers, all cars that in Egypt cost upwards of $40,000.

We arrive at Sheikh Mahmoud's compound late at night. In the opulent greeting room of his north Sinai mansion, the Sheikh, a trafficker of everything from narcotics and weapons, to Eritreans, serves tea and explains how his business grew.

It started with the inter-tribal connections between the Bedouins, he tells us, of Sinai and the Red Sea coast. Bedouin tribes are large, sometimes numbering in the thousands, and tend to extend their reach over vast swaths of land. Most families come from ethnic minorities and are institutionally repressed by each state regime, from Egypt to Eritrea. Because of this, criminal industries tend to thrive, primarily various types of smuggling and narcotics production, in order for the population to subsist. The porous borders and transient nature of some Bedouin tribes allow them to pass through the landscape with ease.

Around 2007, Eritreans in the Sudanese border refugee camps began to disappear. The Shagarab refugee camp in Sudan is the main source of people for traffickers. Many victims point to the Rashaydas, a nomadic Bedouin tribe that roams the Red Sea coast, as major perpetrators. "We all know who they are," says Sister Elsa, an Eritrean nun based in Cairo. "As a girl I played with their camels." Traffickers throw their victims in pickup trucks smeared with motor oil and covered in sand. Through the cover of the desert, they drive up, with as many as twenty Eritreans packed in the bed of the pickup, and pass them from group to group until they reach the Sinai. "If the Rashaydas sell one person for $5,000, when they reach the next gang in Sudan, they sell for about $ 7,500, and so on," says Father Ibrahim.

PICKING UP PEOPLE FROM THE CAMPS is an almost effortless task, because the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR) has limited control of the camps. Instead of travelling up through Egypt and into Israel, the refugees began to be intercepted at the camps and deposited in homes in the Sinai. Kidnappers would force a phone into their hands, and make them call relatives back home to demand ransom. They started small, usually asking for around $2,000. But the Eritrean diaspora is widespread and because of the political situation in the country, the UN tends to resettle them in western countries with relative frequency. Traffickers began to realise this, and assuming that relatives in western countries earn considerably more money, began to charge more. The price of the Eritreans began to raise going up the chain, until it was no longer viable to charge $2,000 per person. $2,000 became $10,000, and soon ransoms were reaching up to $60,000.

"Every Sunday, in Eritrean communities around the world, you'll find someone who is begging [in church]" Father Ibrahim says. Eritrean communities in the diaspora are forced to pool everything they have to free their loved ones and even when they do pay, the kidnappers often demand more. "There are [kidnapped Eritreans] who have been sent to [Egyptian] jail after paying all the money. You pay $30,000 then you go to jail or end up with a bullet or finish up in the hands of the traffickers," he says. After being freed, may Eritreans have been captured by Egyptian police and army and arrested on charges of illegal immigration.

To extort the growing sums of money, the traffickers began beating and torturing their captives while negotiating with their families, or often, on the phone with Father Ibrahim.

"I got a call from a young man who told me he was standing between two bodies", he explains. They had been dead for days, and their bodies were pulsating with maggots.

Kidnapped Eritreans are kept in rooms that are usually windowless and have little furnishing. The Sinai is freezing during winter and boiling in the summer and the Eritreans are fed little and given little water. Traffickers hold lighters to empty soda bottles and drip molten plastic on emaciated backs.

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They leave iron bars on stoves, to press across stomachs. Lack of medical care adds the health risks. Many Eritreans are found with badly infected sores and wounds. Kidnappers sodomise the men with objects and rape the women. They force the kidnapped to rape each other.

"With all the beatings, malnourishment and psychological torture, the health deteriorates and the body ends," says Father Ibrahim. But when someone dies, the guard is punished. Traffickers are businessmen. They don't torture the Eritreans with the intention of killing them; usually it's a guard, a cousin or brother of the trafficker, who does it out of malicious intent.

The Bedouins also keep some Eritreans to use as translators and force them to torture each other. "Eritreans kill their brothers, because they are told, 'If you don't do it you will be killed,'" continues Father Ibrahim. "There are some who refuse to kill, and the trafficker kill them."

Victims also report witnessing Eritrean and Sudanese officials as being participants in the trafficking. In the summer of 2013, the home of a colonel in Asmara, the capital of Eritrea was daubed with graffiti that said, "You have built this house with the kidneys of our children". Many have accused the government of direct involvement in trafficking.

THE BUSINESS OF SMUGGLING is changing again. In July 2013, after the deposal of President Morsi, militant activity began to increase within the Northern Sinai and army checkpoints throughout the peninsula came under attack on a regular basis. In response, General Abdul Fattah Al-Sisi began a campaign against rampant crime in the Northern Sinai. With that came the chaotic scramble to decide what to do with the Eritreans in transit.

The heightened security has effectively sealed off the Sinai Peninsula from the rest of Egypt. Eritreans abandoned by traffickers and saved by sympathetic Bedouins have been left to find their ways to safety. Some have been abandoned in the desert, left to fend for themselves. Others are stuck with their captors, still being starved and tortured. But most have been turned over to the Egyptian authorities and languish in Northern Sinai's police stations and the nation's stinking, sweltering prisons.

Mohamed, who also declined to give his full name, is a journalist based in North Sinai who was arrested on charges of distributing false information. "I was on a bus with some Eritreans when I was being transferred to the courthouse in Sinai. They were given another year in jail without even leaving the truck," he says. Many Eritreans get stuck in a bureaucratic limbo, being shuttled back and forth within Egypt's widespread prison system.

Those caught in prisons are given a choice: go back to Ethiopia or Eritrea. "The Eritrean government will welcome them, then slowly, one by one, they will put them into prison, or military service," says Father Ibrahim. Many families in the diaspora have at least one relative who, upon deportation to Eritrea, was never seen or heard of again.

Those who make it to Cairo face another set of problems entirely. "They get out of Eritrea, they get out of torture, they get out of Sinai, and then they're stuck here," says Father Ibrahim. Unable to legally work, Eritreans live on $22 per month given to them by the international aid organisation, Caritas. They live in cramped conditions in Cairo's poor district of Ard El Lewa or Maadi, an outer lying district, and most suffer from posttraumatic stress disorder. For example, Adam, a seventeen-year-old victim, seeing suffers intense panic attacks around Egyptians. "You can help them medically, but in the mind, they are not there. Sometimes I go to visit them and we pray. Nobody can help them in terms of language, so I'm in contact with them," says Father Ibrahim.

Adam works at a church in downtown Cairo, cleaning the floors and making coffee and tea for the priests and nuns, waiting as the UN processes his relocation paperwork. The process can take anywhere from six months to ten years.

"These are young boys, they forget easily. I see all these boys and they look completely lost," says Ibrahim. "They sleep all day and do nothing to better their lives."

Some women are able to find work, cleaning houses in upscale neighbourhoods. Some are left pregnant after being raped during detention.

Because Eritreans tend to cluster together, they are also vulnerable to further attacks. "Kidnappers know where to find Eritreans in Cairo. They know where they gather. They know what they look like. They can be targeted easily," Father Ibrahim says. Several Eritrean trafficking victims detailed receiving harassment after being released from custody. Bedouin kidnappers followed them into the city, and continued attempting to extort money from them.

"You go out of [Eritrea] looking for a better, secure place, and then you are put under the trafficker. You don't have a place back home. People are making thousands out of you," says Father Ibrahim.

A year ago, another Eritrean clergy member, who for the sake of her own safety, refused to be named for this article, travelled back to Eritrea. On a visit to a church in Asmara, she pleaded with young men and women, telling them the dangers of the trip. Out of the audience, a teenage boy stood up.

"What can we do? Either we die there or we die here."

The interviewees have not been photographed in order to protect their identities.